Rebecca: Plot Summary

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

Download PDF

Written by: Nick Redgrove
Reviewed by: Kate Lee
Updated on 15 October 2024

Plot Summary

One of the most helpful things you can do in preparation for the exam is to "know" the plot of Rebecca thoroughly. Once you know the text well, you should be comfortable and familiar with key events that you can then link to larger ideas. Having an in-depth knowledge and understanding of the text will help you to gain confidence to find the most relevant references to support your response.

Below you will find:

- **An overview of the novel**
- **A plot summary broken down into sections of the novel**

Overview

Rebecca begins with an unnamed narrator recalling events from the past. The narrator is travelling in Europe with a companion and they reminisce about Manderley, the English estate they were forced to leave. The narrative then flashes back to the narrator's time in Monte Carlo, when she was employed by an elderly American socialite. Here, she encounters Maximilian (Maxim) de Winter, a wealthy widower whose late wife, Rebecca, died in a tragic sailing accident. A swift courtship between the narrator and Maxim leads to marriage and the couple begin their life together at Manderley. As the novel progresses, the narrator struggles with her growing sense of inadequacy in comparison to the memory of Rebecca. She perceives Rebecca as the **epitome** of glamour and sophistication and becomes convinced that she cannot measure up to this ideal in Maxim's eyes. Mrs Danvers, the housekeeper, exacerbates the narrator's insecurities by incessantly highlighting Maxim's enduring love for Rebecca.

During Manderley's annual costume ball, the second Mrs de Winter, encouraged by Mrs Danvers, wears a costume reminiscent of one worn by Rebecca just before her death. This deeply unsettles Maxim and he asks her to change. The narrator is confronted by Mrs Danvers, who convinces her that Maxim no longer desires her and encourages her to leap from a second-floor window. However, a sudden disturbance caused by a shipwreck prevents this occurring. The discovery of a sunken sailing boat, containing Rebecca's body, becomes the

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

avoid scandal, Maxim allowed her to maintain a façade of the perfect wife publicly while living a private life unrestrained. In a fit of rage, Maxim shot her and sank her body in a sailboat and identified another corpse weeks later as Rebecca.

Maxim is seemingly exonerated after the coroner rules Rebecca's death a suicide though he faces a resurgence of accusations when Rebecca's lover, Jack Favell, claims that Maxim murdered her. The magistrate seeks a motive for Rebecca's supposed suicide and it emerges that Rebecca, on the day of her death, had visited a London doctor. Upon questioning the doctor, Mr Baker, it is disclosed that Rebecca was battling cancer. This information offers a plausible motive for suicide and absolves Maxim of suspicion. Mrs Danvers mysteriously disappears and when the de Winters return from London to Manderley, they find the house ablaze.

Help me understand

Chapter-by-Chapter Plot Summary

Chapters 1–6

- The narrative unfolds in a **retrospective** manner through the eyes of an unnamed narrator, with the initial chapter set in the present
- In this opening sequence, the narrator is residing abroad and experiences a dream about Manderley
- The narrator introduces her husband and retraces her memories, beginning with her employment as a companion to Mrs Van Hopper, a wealthy American residing in Monte Carlo
- Mrs Van Hopper orchestrates encounters with Maxim de Winter
- When Mrs Van Hopper falls ill, the narrator shares lunch with Maxim
- Maxim takes her for a drive, describes the beauty of Manderley and lends her a poetry book dedicated “from Rebecca”
- The narrator is informed of the tragedy of Maxim's first wife and she confesses her love for Maxim
- As Mrs Van Hopper and the narrator prepare to leave Monte Carlo, the narrator visits Maxim's room to bid farewell
- Maxim proposes marriage and she accepts

Chapters 7–11

- Upon their return to Manderley, the couple are welcomed by the staff
- Mrs Danvers displays an outward disdain for the new Mrs de Winter
- The following morning, the narrator suffers anxiety and fears that she may disrupt the former routines established by Rebecca
- At lunch, Maxim's sister Beatrice and his agent, Frank Crawley, visit
- Beatrice offers well-intentioned advice and urges the narrator not to be intimidated by Mrs Danvers

disabled man who lives on a nearby farm), in a cottage by the cove
- Maxin becomes angered by her visit to the cottage
- Over the ensuing weeks, visitors frequently **reminisce** about the "old days" at Manderley and comment on Rebecca's popularity
- In a conversation with Frank, the narrator mentions the Manderley Ball and the cottage
- Frank reveals that the cottage was where Rebecca used to moor her boat, which tragically capsized, leading to her drowning
- Frank reassures the narrator that her qualities are just as good as Rebecca's and comments on her positive influence on Maxim

Chapters 12–18

- The haunting presence of Rebecca continues to plague the narrator and fosters her sense of inadequacy
- In Maxim's absence, the narrator ventures to the cove and encounters Ben in the cottage
- Ben discloses that Rebecca had threatened him with asylum if he revealed seeing her there
- Upon returning to the house, the narrator observes a suspicious interaction between Mrs Danvers and a man called Jack Favell
- Seeking solace in the west wing, the narrator discovers the preserved rooms that Mrs Danvers has maintained as a shrine to Rebecca
- Mrs Danvers recounts the events leading to Rebecca's drowning and reveals her devotion to Rebecca
- Beatrice informs the narrator that Jack Favell is Rebecca's cousin
- In an angry confrontation between Maxim and Mrs Danvers, the narrator hears Maxim insist that Jack Favell must stay away from Manderley
- The narrator decides to hold a ball at Manderley
- Mrs Danvers proposes that the narrator replicates one of the portraits within Manderley and she agrees
- On the night of the ball, Maxim sees her dress and coldly instructs her to change
- Beatrice discloses that the dress mirrors the one chosen by Rebecca for the last ball
- Convinced that her marriage has failed, the narrator confronts Mrs Danvers in Rebecca's room
- She challenges Mrs Danvers about the deception with the costume but Mrs Danvers extols Rebecca's extraordinary life and virtues
- Mrs Danvers advises the narrator to leave Manderley, asserting that Maxim does not desire her presence
- The narrator contemplates jumping from the window but is interrupted by the sound of rockets from the bay

Chapters 19–27

- A diver makes the chilling discovery of Rebecca's sunken boat
- Maxim confesses to the narrator that he shot Rebecca, placed her body in the cabin and deliberately sank the boat

she was pregnant by another man
- Struggling to concoct a **plausible** narrative, they both hope to convince others that Rebecca's death was a tragic accident
- The inquest reveals that deliberate holes were made in the bottom of the boat and so the verdict shifts to suicide
- Favell challenges the suicide verdict and vows to seek justice for Rebecca
- Favell discloses their affair and presents a note from Rebecca, inviting him to the cottage on the day of her death
- Favell attempts to blackmail Maxim, though Maxim refuses and calls in the magistrate
- Favell accuses Maxim of murder and implies Ben may have been a witness, though Ben denies having seen anything
- Favell seeks confirmation of his relationship with Rebecca from Mrs Danvers but she dismisses it as merely "a game" to Rebecca
- It is revealed that Rebecca had a doctor's appointment on the day of her death
- A visit to her doctor reveals that Rebecca had cancer and would have survived only a few more months
- Maxim receives a call from Frank at Manderley who reports that Mrs Danvers has suddenly disappeared
- Maxim and the narrator decide to return to Manderley
- As they approach the house, they see Manderley ablaze

Teacher only

Test your students on this in just a few clicks

Create exam-aligned tests

Tailor format & difficulty

Quizzes or homework in minutes

Try Test Builder

Was this revision note helpful? Yes No

Resources

Learning Hub

Scholarship

Join

Past Papers

Solution Banks

Sitemap

Dashboard

Overview

Brand ambassador

Profile

Subscription

Settings

Log out

Company

About us

Exam Specificity

Content Quality

Promotions

Jobs

Terms

Privacy

Cookie Policy

Help and Support

Subjects

Biology

Chemistry

Physics

Maths

Geography

English Literature

Psychology

All Subjects

© Copyright 2015–2026 Save My Exams Ltd. All Rights Reserved.

Neither IBO nor College Board were involved in the production of, and do not endorse, the resources created by Save My Exams.